



Physician Update: COVID-19 Vaccine 2025-26 Season

Quick Facts



- **Cost:** Always **\$0** for members.
- **Eligibility:** KP recommends and provides vaccination for **all patients 6 months and older**, regardless of FDA's narrower authorization.
- **No Prescription Needed:** Members only need to review vaccine information sheet and provide consent.
- **Why Broader Than FDA?** Kaiser Permanente's recommendations are based on a population health approach—prioritizing protection for children, families, and those at risk of transmission or severe outcomes.

FDA v. Kaiser Permanente Recommendations

FDA 2025-2026 Guidance

- Recommends vaccination for adults **65+** and individuals with certain medical conditions (e.g. diabetes, heart disease, immunocompromise).
- Focused on highest-risk adults to prevent hospitalization and death.
- Narrower approval reflects limited authorization language, rather than new safety concerns.

Kaiser Permanente Guidance

- Recommends vaccination for **all individuals 6 months and older**, based on review by KP infectious disease experts and alignment with leading medical societies.
- Focused on broad protection across age groups to reduce transmission, overall illness, and long COVID.
- Broader recommendation reflects **preventive care philosophy**, health equity, and community-wide benefit.

Vaccine Safety and Effectiveness

- The 2025-26 COVID-19 vaccine underwent **extensive clinical testing** for safety and immune response across multiple age groups.
- **No new safety concerns** have emerged; real-world data continues to show that vaccination significantly reduces hospitalization, severe illness, and post-COVID complications.
- Use beyond FDA's specified population is considered "off-label," which is common in medical practice (~20% of prescriptions).
- Vaccines, such as MMR and HPV, have also been safely administered off-label when supported by evidence.



Pediatric Focus: AAP Recommendations

Infants and Children (6 – 23 Months)



The American Academy of Pediatrics (AAP) considers infants and young children in this age range to be at **high risk for severe COVID-19**. The AAP recommends vaccination for all without contraindications:

- **Unvaccinated:** Begin initial vaccine series.
- **Incomplete series:** Complete the initial vaccine series.
- **Completed series:** Receive a single 2025-26 dose.
- **History of infection (symptomatic or asymptomatic):** Still vaccinate to ensure adequate immune protection.

Children and Adolescents (2 – 18 Years)

The AAP recommends a single, age-appropriate 2025-26 COVID-19 vaccine dose for:

- Children and adolescents at high risk for severe disease.
- Residents of long-term care or congregate settings.
- Unvaccinated individuals, or those with high-risk household contacts.
- Any child whose parent or guardian requests protection from COVID-19.

➔ These recommendations align closely with Kaiser Permanente's approach, emphasizing **broad access and proactive vaccination** to protect both pediatric patients and their families.

Clinical Scenarios

Case 1: Healthy 30-Year-Old Teacher

A 30-year-old teacher expresses uncertainty about vaccination because the FDA guidance does not explicitly include her age group.

Clinical Consideration: Teachers have daily close contact with children and families. Vaccination can help reduce infection risk, absenteeism, and classroom spread while supporting community protection.

Case 2: 68-Year-Old with Diabetes

A 68-year-old with diabetes reports prior COVID-19 infection and questions the need for an additional dose.

Clinical Consideration: Immunity following infection declines over time. The updated 2025-26 formulation targets current variants and continues to offer strong protection against hospitalization and severe outcomes.

Case 3: Parent of a 7-Year-Old

A parent asks whether vaccination is necessary, given the FDA's limited recommendation for children.

Clinical Consideration: Pediatric vaccination remains safe and effective, preventing complications such as MIS-C and reducing household transmission. It also supports uninterrupted school attendance and family well-being.

Case 4: 45-Year-Old Marathon Runner

A healthy adult questions the value of vaccination, given their low perceived risk.

Clinical Consideration: Even healthy individuals can develop long COVID or transmit infection of higher-risk contacts. Vaccination reduces both infection risk and severity, contributing to broader community protection.



Key Takeaways

- Both Kaiser Permanente and the AAP recommend COVID-19 vaccination **for everyone 6 months and older**.
- The vaccine remains **safe, effective, and free**, representing one of our strongest tools to protect patients and communities against severe illness this respiratory virus season.

Supporting Information and Resources

- [Scheduling](#)
- [High-risk conditions](#)
- [2025-26 COVID Vaccine Member FAQs](#)
- [AAP Immunization Schedule](#)
- [Internal KP ID and Pediatrics Guidance](#)